



Flat as pancake: Australia pace legend Dennis Lillee denounced a pitch in Pakistan as a "graveyard for bowlers" in 1980, but more than 40 years later little has changed. AFP

» STATISTICAL ANALYSIS

PITCH IMPERFECT!

A statistical exploration of the patterns of runs scored and the results of Test matches that have turned pitches in Pakistan into a **bowler's nightmare.**

Shayan Acharya and Pranay Rajiv
shayan.acharya@thehindu.co.in,
pranay.rajiv@thehindu.co.in

Pakistan needed a used Multan pitch and a spin-confounded England batting unit to break its remarkable 11-game winless streak at home in Test cricket.

Pakistan's out-of-the-box idea of reusing the surface stemmed from a humiliating innings defeat in the first Test against England, despite scoring 556 runs in the first innings.

The Multan win also marked a significant departure from Pakistan's

home Test strategy in the last five years, which had heavily favoured batters.

Since 2019, when Test cricket returned to Pakistan after a decade-long break due to the Lahore terror attack, batters have averaged 38.03 runs per dismissal in the country — the highest among all Test-playing nations during this period.

Both home and away batters have capitalised on the pliant, flat Pakistani pitches, swelling their aggregates. In the 17 Tests Pakistan has hosted in this period, batters have accumulated 48 centuries, the second-most in any country, behind

only England, which has seen 59 tons.

However, when it comes to centuries per game, Pakistan tops the chart by a significant margin — 2.82 hundreds per game, with Sri Lanka's 2.26 a distant second.

The rise in individual hundreds has also translated into teams consistently tallying huge totals. In the last five years, there have been eight 500+ innings totals in Test cricket in Pakistan, the joint-highest among all countries, alongside Australia.

With run-scoring becoming easier and bowling subsequently more difficult, Pakistan has seen a larger